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Almost 90 years ago, T.S. Eliot wrote a whimsical collection of playful poems titled *Old Possum's Book of Practical Cats* for his godchildren. In 1977, musical genius Andrew Lloyd Webber saw potential in them and started setting them to tunes. A musical production came together when producer Cameron Mackintosh, director Trevor Nunn and choreographer Gillian Lynne, along with a stellar cast, brought a full-fledged musical to audiences in London's West End in 1981 and New York's Broadway in 1982. Finally, 45 years later, the same iconic musical is making its way to the Grand Theatre at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre (NMACC) in Mumbai.

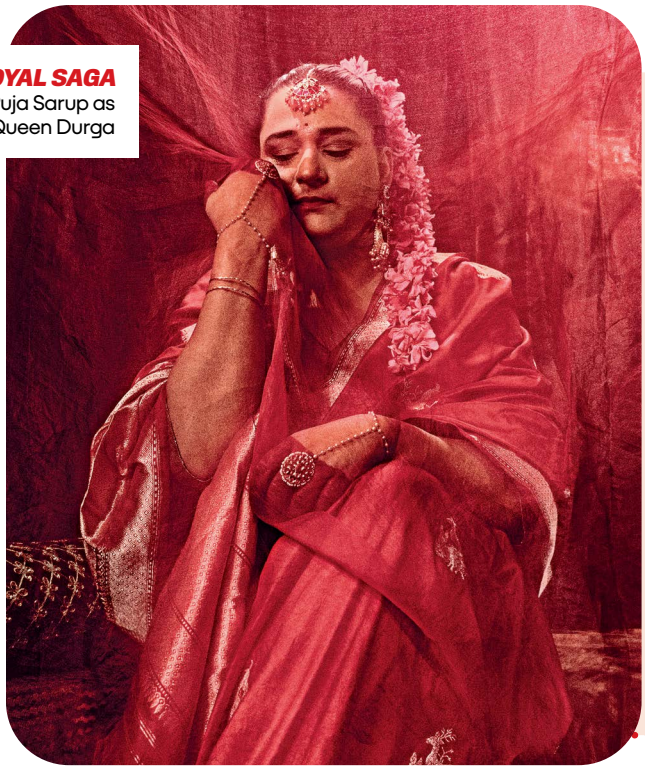
The award-winning and money-spinning story is set in a junkyard, with a variety of alley cats and their individual quirks introduced to the audience, while all of them are preparing to attend the Jellicle Ball. This is an annual celebration where one of the 'Jellicle Cats' is chosen for ascension to the 'Heaviside Layer' to be reborn into a new life. It's a musical so familiar, so endearing that it is considered timeless. And yet, it has evolved down the decades. "One of the reasons *Cats* has endured for over 40 years is that it constantly reinvents itself through the artists who inhabit it," says resident director Matt Krzan. The original production, he notes, broke boundaries in its own time, and "inclusivity is very much part of how we cast and build the company" even today. "Modern productions reflect a far broader range of performers, identities, body types and movement styles than audiences might have seen decades ago," adds Krzan. "We remain rooted in the classic original staging, but theatre is always in conversation with the world around it—and that ongoing evolution is part of why *Cats* still has nine lives."

According to Krzan, the choreography remains firmly grounded in Lynne's iconic original work, which is really the heartbeat of *Cats*. It's one of the most recognisable movement languages in musical theatre history—athletic, feline and incredibly specific. That said, every new company brings fresh energy and nuance to it. The challenge is preserving the precision, while allowing performers to make the roles their own. "The beauty of *Cats* is that every performer brings their own feline personality and lived experience into the tribe," he says.

Cindy Ann Abrahams, who plays Grizabella, one of the musical's most poignant characters, shares, "It's been



BEHIND THE WHISKERS
Cindy Ann Abrahams, who plays Grizabella, (right) resident director Matt Krzan



ROYAL SAGA
Puja Sarup as Queen Durga

THEATRE ▼

Palace Intrigues

ADITYA RAWAL'S CRITICALLY-ACCLAIMED PLAY, **THE QUEEN**, *RETURNS TO PRITHVI THEATRE*

Imagine being a revered queen and trusted royal counsel, only to find yourself abruptly shunted to the palace's west wing because your husband took a younger wife. Enter Queen Durga, the fiercely compelling protagonist of playwright Aditya Rawal's *The Queen*, brought to life by Puja Sarup. Returning to Prithvi Theatre later this month before heading to Pune, the play captures a single, high-stakes day where a 'dethroned' queen must navigate her fading relevance just as news arrives of an